Learned Regularization for Robust Image Reconstruction:

A Comparative Study of Plug-and-Play Priors under Noise, Undersampling, Model Mismatch, and Distribution Shift

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Abstract

We study sparse-view computed tomography as a linear inverse problem and compare classical variational regularization against a learned image prior used inside a Plug-and-Play proximal-gradient (PnP-PGD) scheme, benchmarking it against filtered back-projection, Tikhonov and total-variation (TV) regularization. We use disjoint train/validation/test splits, per-condition hyperparameter tuning, paired statistical tests, measurements simulated on a finer grid to avoid the inverse crime, and three independently trained denoisers per configuration. The learned prior improves PSNR by up to 4 dB over TV at moderate-to-high noise ($\sigma \geq 0.05$) and for 5–90 projection angles; in the near noise-free regime TV remains ahead, by an amount (1–6 dB) that depends on the forward-model mismatch of the simulated data. Reconstruction quality peaks after a handful of iterations and then degrades while the data residual rises. The advantage narrows under forward-model mismatch and reverses under distribution shift: a prior trained on MNIST loses to TV by 3–4 dB on Fashion-MNIST and on a Shepp–Logan phantom, whereas a prior trained on Fashion-MNIST beats TV on Fashion-MNIST by 2.2 dB, so the failure is one of prior mismatch rather than of the PnP scheme itself. An error decomposition along the singular vectors of the forward operator shows that, under mismatch, the reconstruction places up to three times the true energy in the weakly determined subspace. Finally, lesion-insertion experiments show that even in distribution the PSNR-tuned PnP reconstruction detects small inserted lesions less reliably than TV (paired AUC 0.69 vs. 0.91 for a 0.75 px lesion), attenuating them rather than inventing structure, whereas under prior mismatch it creates lesion-like blobs up to an order of magnitude more often than TV. Re-tuning towards lesion fidelity recovers TV-level detection only at the price of its PSNR advantage or of false structure. We argue that task-based and robustness evaluation should be standard components of learned-prior reconstruction studies.

1 Introduction

Image reconstruction from indirect, noisy, and incomplete measurements is a classical ill-posed inverse problem, arising in computed tomography (CT), magnetic resonance imaging, and many other imaging modalities. Given a forward operator A and noisy measurements

$$y = Ax + n, \tag{1}$$

the goal is to recover x from y when A is ill-conditioned or rank-deficient, as is the case for sparse-view CT with few projection angles. Classical approaches address ill-posedness through explicit regularization, solving

$$\hat{x} = \arg\min_x \ \tfrac{1}{2}\|Ax - y\|_2^2 + \lambda R(x), \tag{2}$$

with R a hand-crafted prior such as Tikhonov (L2) or total variation (TV) penalties. In recent years, learned image priors – most notably through Plug-and-Play (PnP) methods and deep unrolling – have been proposed to replace or augment hand-crafted regularizers with a denoising neural network, exploiting the empirical observation that image denoisers implicitly encode rich natural-image statistics [10].

While learned priors frequently outperform classical regularization on in-distribution benchmarks, a growing body of work has raised concerns about their *robustness*: sensitivity to distribution shift, lack of convergence guarantees, and instabilities under small perturbations of the input or forward model [1]. Many project-level or introductory studies of learned reconstruction report only in-distribution accuracy, leaving these robustness questions unaddressed.

This paper documents a controlled, small-scale study designed explicitly to probe these questions. We deliberately restrict scope to a simple, cheaply reproducible setting – sparse-view tomography of 28×28 MNIST-derived images – in order to run a thorough grid of experiments with proper train/validation/test protocol rather than a single headline comparison. Our contributions are:

- A from-scratch implementation of a sparse-view Radon operator with exact adjoint, classical regularization baselines (FBP, Tikhonov, TV-ADMM), and a PnP-PGD solver using a noise-conditioned DnCNN prior.
- A systematic comparison of PSNR/SSIM accuracy across measurement noise levels and numbers of projection angles, with validation-tuned hyperparameters and paired significance testing.
- A convergence analysis explaining why PnP-PGD selects very few iterations under validation tuning, showing a peak-then-decay pattern in reconstruction accuracy that is not visible from residual curves alone.
- Robustness studies – forward-model mismatch (angle offset and jitter) and train-test distribution shift (Fashion-MNIST, EMNIST, and a CT phantom) – run with hyperparameters frozen at their nominal values, exposing failure modes not visible under in-distribution evaluation alone.
- Data simulated on a finer grid than the reconstruction grid, to remove the inverse crime, with a sensitivity analysis over how the finer-grid object is constructed (Section 4.5).
- An error decomposition along the singular vectors of the forward operator, separating the weakly determined subspace from its orthogonal complement, with an "injection" and an "alignment" statistic that quantify prior-driven content (Section 4.6).
- Controls for the learned prior itself: three denoiser seeds, a wider training noise range, and a matched-prior control trained on the shifted distribution (Section 4.7).
- A task-based evaluation by lesion insertion, with an operating-point study asking whether the detectability loss can be removed by re-tuning (Sections 4.8 and 4.9).

2 Related Work

Variational regularization. Tikhonov regularization and total variation [8] remain standard baselines for ill-posed inverse problems due to their convexity, well-understood convergence prop-

erties, and interpretability. TV in particular is a strong prior for piecewise-constant images, which makes it a competitive baseline for digit-like data such as MNIST.

Plug-and-Play priors. Venkatakrishnan et al. [10] introduced the idea of replacing the proximal operator of a variational regularizer with an off-the-shelf denoiser inside an ADMM or proximal-gradient iteration. Subsequent work analyzed convergence conditions for PnP under assumptions on the denoiser (e.g. non-expansiveness or bounded Lipschitz constant) [4, 9]; without such constraints, plain CNN denoisers offer no convergence guarantee, a point directly relevant to the convergence behavior we observe in Section 4.

Learned denoisers. DnCNN [12] demonstrated that residual CNNs trained for Gaussian denoising across a range of noise levels generalize well as plug-in priors. We adopt this noise-conditioning strategy so that a single trained network can serve across the PnP iteration trajectory, where the effective denoising strength is a tunable hyperparameter.

Instabilities and robustness. Antun et al. [1] showed that learned reconstruction methods for CT and MRI can be unstable to small perturbations and structural changes not present in training data, in some cases more so than classical methods. Related work on distribution shift in learned inverse problem solvers [5] similarly finds that accuracy gains from learned priors can shrink or reverse under shift. Our distribution shift and forward-model mismatch experiments are a small-scale, project-level instantiation of this broader concern, and our findings (Section 5) are consistent with it.

Hallucinations, the inverse crime and task-based assessment. Bhadra et al. [3] define a hallucination in tomographic reconstruction as image content that is not determined by the measurement data, i.e. content that lives in the null space of the imaging operator and is supplied by the prior; we adopt this view and extend it to the weakly determined subspace of a finite-precision operator (Section 3.6). Generating data with the same discrete model that is later inverted is known as the inverse crime [6, 11] and tends to overstate the accuracy of methods that exploit the exact model; we remove it in Section 3.5. Finally, we follow the task-based view of image quality [2]: fidelity metrics such as PSNR need not predict whether a clinically relevant feature survives reconstruction, so we also measure detection of inserted lesions.

3 Methodology

3.1 Forward operator

We construct a sparse-view Radon transform $A \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times n}$ as an explicit dense matrix by applying the discrete Radon transform to each canonical basis image and stacking the resulting sinogram columns. This gives an exact adjoint $A^\top$ (rather than an approximate one, as is common with implicit/fast Radon implementations), which is important for the PnP gradient step, and allows the reconstruction operator to be perturbed independently of the data-generating operator for the mismatch experiments in Section 4. Images are 28×28; the number of projection angles and, where relevant, an angular offset or per-angle jitter are configurable.

3.2 Classical baselines

Filtered back-projection (FBP) applies the standard ramp filter and inverse Radon transform. **Tikhonov regularization** solves

$$\hat{x} = \arg\min_x \tfrac{1}{2}\|Ax - y\|_2^2 + \tfrac{\lambda}{2}\|x\|_2^2 = (A^\top A + \lambda I)^{-1} A^\top y, \tag{3}$$

computed in closed form. **Total variation** solves

$$\hat{x} = \arg\min_x \tfrac{1}{2}\|Ax - y\|_2^2 + \lambda\,\mathrm{TV}(x) \tag{4}$$

via ADMM with an isotropic TV penalty and a finite-difference operator D, splitting $z = Dx$ and applying the standard shrinkage update on the split variable.

3.3 Learned prior: PnP proximal gradient

We train a DnCNN denoiser D_σ conditioned on the noise level σ (following the FFDNet-style noise-map input), on clean MNIST digits corrupted with Gaussian noise $\sigma \sim \mathcal{U}(0, \sigma_{\max})$, $\sigma_{\max} = 0.3$, using residual learning and an ℓ_2 loss. A single trained network is then used across all PnP experiments, with σ_d (the denoising strength argument passed at inference) treated as a tunable hyperparameter distinct from the training distribution's noise range.

Reconstruction proceeds by proximal-gradient iteration, replacing the proximal operator of an explicit regularizer with the learned denoiser:

$$x_{k+1} = D_{\sigma_d}\big(x_k - \eta\, A^\top(Ax_k - y)\big), \qquad \eta = 1/L(A^\top A), \tag{5}$$

where $L(A^\top A)$ is the largest eigenvalue of $A^\top A$, estimated by power iteration. The iteration is initialized at the FBP reconstruction. Algorithm 1 summarizes the procedure.

Algorithm 1 PnP proximal gradient (PnP-PGD)

Require: measurements y, operator A, denoiser D, strength σ_d, step η, iterations K

$x_0 \leftarrow \mathrm{FBP}(y)$
for $k = 0, \ldots, K-1$ **do**
  $g_k \leftarrow A^\top(Ax_k - y)$
  $x_{k+1} \leftarrow D_{\sigma_d}(x_k - \eta\, g_k)$
end for
return x_K

3.4 Evaluation protocol

Data are split into disjoint training, validation, and test subsets. All hyperparameters – λ for Tikhonov and TV, and (σ_d, K) for PnP – are selected by grid search maximizing mean validation PSNR, independently for each experimental condition (noise level or number of angles) in Experiments 1–2, and then evaluated once on the disjoint test set. For the robustness experiments (Section 4, E3–E4), hyperparameters are tuned once at a single nominal condition and then *frozen* across all mismatch/shift conditions, reflecting a realistic deployment scenario where a reconstruction pipeline is not retuned for every possible operating condition. We report PSNR and SSIM as mean with 95% confidence intervals over test images, and use a paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test (matched test images and noise realizations) to assess the significance of PnP vs. TV differences.

3.5 Data simulated on a finer grid

In E1–E5 the data are generated with the matrix A used for reconstruction (an "inverse crime" [6, 11]). For the experiments of Sections 4.5–4.9 we instead simulate measurements on a finer grid. The 28×28 image x is upsampled by an odd integer factor $f = 5$ (to 140×140) with bicubic interpolation and clipped to $[0, 1]$, projected with the same discrete Radon transform at the same angles, and every f adjacent detector bins are summed onto the 40-bin detector of the reconstruction operator, giving $y = \mathcal{S}(x) + n$ with $\mathcal{S} \neq A$. Reconstructions use A, and all metrics use the original 28×28 image as ground truth. The model error $\|\mathcal{S}(x) - Ax\|_2$ averages 0.09 at 20 angles (0.05 at 5 and 0.17 at 90 angles), i.e. 6% of the noise norm $\sigma\sqrt{m}$, $m = 40\,n_{\text{angles}}$, at $\sigma = 0.05$ and 31% at $\sigma = 0.01$. Because bicubic upsampling smooths the object, we also report a nearest-neighbour variant (object unchanged, model error 0.03) and a bilinear variant (model error ≈ 0.10, a stronger smoothing) as a sensitivity band. All hyperparameters are re-tuned on validation data simulated in the same way.

3.6 Weakly determined subspaces and prior-driven content

Let $A = U\Sigma V^\top$ be the SVD of the dense operator, with singular values $s_1 \geq \cdots \geq s_n$. For a threshold τ let $W_\tau = \operatorname{span}\{v_i : s_i < \tau s_1\}$ and let P_τ be the orthogonal projector onto W_τ. For 20 angles the operator has an exact null space of dimension 79 (singular values at machine precision), followed by a continuum of very small singular values with no gap; we therefore use $\tau = 0.05$ as the headline choice, giving $\dim W_{0.05} = 319$ of the 784 dimensions (and report $\tau = 0.10$ and the exact null space as sensitivity checks). A gradient step $x \mapsto x - \eta A^\top(Ax - y)$ never changes the component of x in the null space of A, so null-space content of a PnP reconstruction is supplied by the denoiser alone. For a reconstruction $\hat{x}$ and ground truth x we report

$$\|\hat{x} - x\|_2^2 = \|P_\tau(\hat{x} - x)\|_2^2 + \|(I - P_\tau)(\hat{x} - x)\|_2^2 \quad \text{(orthogonal split)}, \tag{6}$$

$$\iota = \frac{\sum \|P_\tau \hat{x}\|_2^2}{\sum \|P_\tau x\|_2^2} \quad \text{(injection)}, \tag{7}$$

$$c = \frac{\sum \langle P_\tau \hat{x}, P_\tau x\rangle}{\sqrt{\sum \|P_\tau \hat{x}\|_2^2 \sum \|P_\tau x\|_2^2}} \quad \text{(alignment)}, \tag{8}$$

with sums over test images (pooled ratios). $\iota > 1$ means that the reconstruction places more energy in W_τ than the true images contain there; c measures how much of that content points in the right direction. These statistics cannot by themselves distinguish prior-driven structure from amplified noise, so we interpret them only in comparisons with identical noise, data and solver settings.

3.7 Denoiser seeds, noise range and matched-prior control

Besides the single MNIST denoiser of Section 3.3 we train, with the same architecture and optimiser (8 epochs, Adam, cosine schedule): (i) three MNIST denoisers with $\sigma_{\max} = 0.3$ (seeds 0–2); (ii) three MNIST denoisers with $\sigma_{\max} = 0.5$, which allows σ_d up to 0.5 and removes the grid-edge tuning at $\sigma = 0.2$ observed in E1; (iii) three denoisers trained on the Fashion-MNIST training split ($\sigma_{\max} = 0.3$). In the matched-prior control, all methods (Tikhonov, TV, PnP) are tuned on held-out Fashion-MNIST training images and tested on the Fashion-MNIST test split. The σ_d grid is extended to $\{0.005, \ldots, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5\}$ for all denoisers.

3.8 Lesion-insertion protocol

A lesion is an additive Gaussian blob, $x_{\text{les}} = \text{clip}_{[0,1]}\big(x + c\,e^{-\|p-p_0\|^2/(2\sigma_l^2)}\big)$, inserted at a random integer location p_0 of the central 16×16 region of a test image, with $\sigma_l \in \{0.5, 0.75, 1.25, 2.0\}$ px

and contrast $c \in \{0.25, 0.5\}$ (eight lesion types). We reconstruct the lesion-present image and the lesion-absent original with independent noise realizations ($\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles, crime-free data), using the same locations for every method. A lesion is *valid* if its inserted contrast in the ground truth is at least 50% of nominal (a lesion placed on a saturated stroke is clipped away); invalid cases are excluded for all methods, leaving 157–197 of 200 images per type. The observer is a location-known statistic, the *local contrast*: the mean of the image in a disc of radius $\rho = \lceil 1.5\sigma_l \rceil$ minus its mean in the surrounding annulus of width 3 px. We report

- the *paired AUC*: the fraction of images for which the statistic is larger in the lesion-present than in the lesion-absent reconstruction of the same base image (the background cancels; ties count one half);
- the *retention* $R = \mathrm{E}[t(\hat{x}_{\mathrm{present}}) - t(\hat{x}_{\mathrm{absent}})]/\mathrm{E}[t(x_{\mathrm{les}}) - t(x)]$, which is 1 if the lesion contrast is preserved and below 1 if it is attenuated;
- the number of *false lesions* per lesion-absent image: local maxima of the contrast map of the reconstruction whose response is at least θ, half the response of the nominal lesion, and for which the ground truth has no contrast above $\theta/2$ within 2 px;
- the lesion's *observability*, the fraction of its energy outside $W_{0.05}$.

For the operating-point study (Section 4.9) we sweep 45 PnP settings ($\sigma_d \in \{0.02, 0.05, 0.1, 0.15, 0.2\}$, $K \in \{1, 2, 3, 5, 10, 25, 50, 100, 200\}$) and 9 values of the TV weight, choose operating points on 200 held-out *in-distribution* validation images (disjoint from the images used for PSNR tuning) and report them on the test sets, so that the choice is neither made on the evaluation images nor informed by the shifted distribution.

4 Experiments

4.1 E1–E2: In-distribution accuracy under noise and undersampling

Table 1 reports test-set PSNR for representative conditions (20 projection angles, varying measurement noise σ; and fixed $\sigma = 0.05$, varying number of angles).

Table 1: Test PSNR (dB) under varying noise and angular undersampling. Best method per row in bold. PnP–TV column reports the paired Wilcoxon test outcome. Data generated with the reconstruction operator itself ("inverse crime"); see Table 4 and Table 5 for data simulated on a finer grid.

Condition	FBP	Tikhonov	TV	PnP-DnCNN	PnP − TV
σ=0, 20 angles	24.2	28.9	**36.0**	29.6	-6.4 ($p < 10^{-30}$)
σ=0.01, 20 angles	23.1	24.1	29.0	29.1	$+0.07$ (n.s., $p = 0.27$)
σ=0.05, 20 angles	15.5	17.1	20.2	**24.0**	$+3.85$ ($p < 10^{-30}$)
σ=0.1, 20 angles	10.4	14.7	16.9	**19.9**	$+3.0$ ($p < 10^{-30}$)
σ=0.2, 20 angles	6.6	12.9	14.3	**15.3**	$+1.0$ ($p < 10^{-10}$)
5 angles, σ=0.05	9.1	14.2	15.5	**17.7**	$+2.15$ ($p < 10^{-25}$)
10 angles, σ=0.05	12.1	15.9	18.4	**21.4**	$+3.05$ ($p < 10^{-30}$)
90 angles, σ=0.05	20.6	20.0	24.1	**27.1**	$+3.04$ ($p < 10^{-30}$)

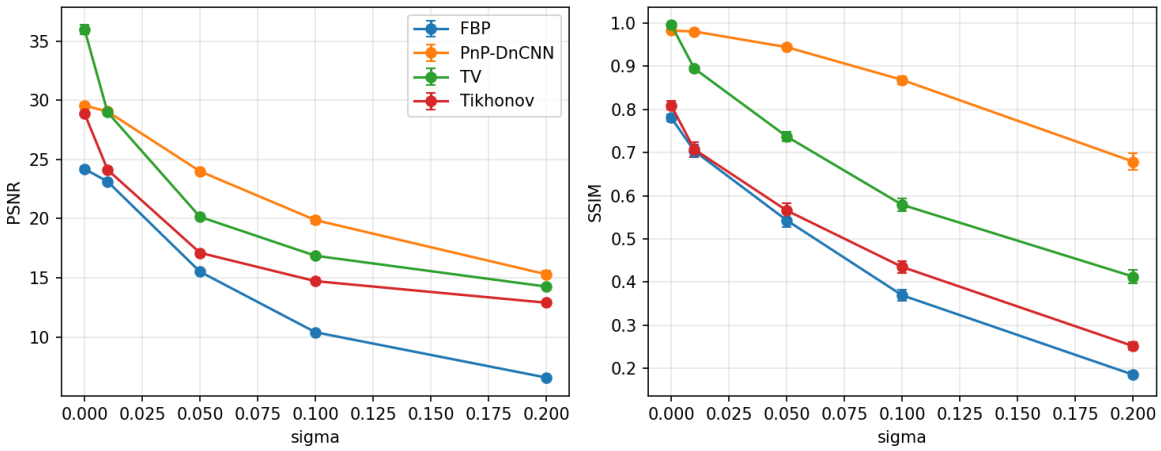


Figure 1: Reconstruction accuracy (PSNR, left; SSIM, right) vs. measurement noise level σ, for all four methods at a fixed 20 projection angles. TV is the strongest method at $\sigma \leq 0.01$; PnP-DnCNN overtakes all classical baselines for $\sigma \geq 0.05$. Error bars denote 95% confidence intervals over 200 test images.

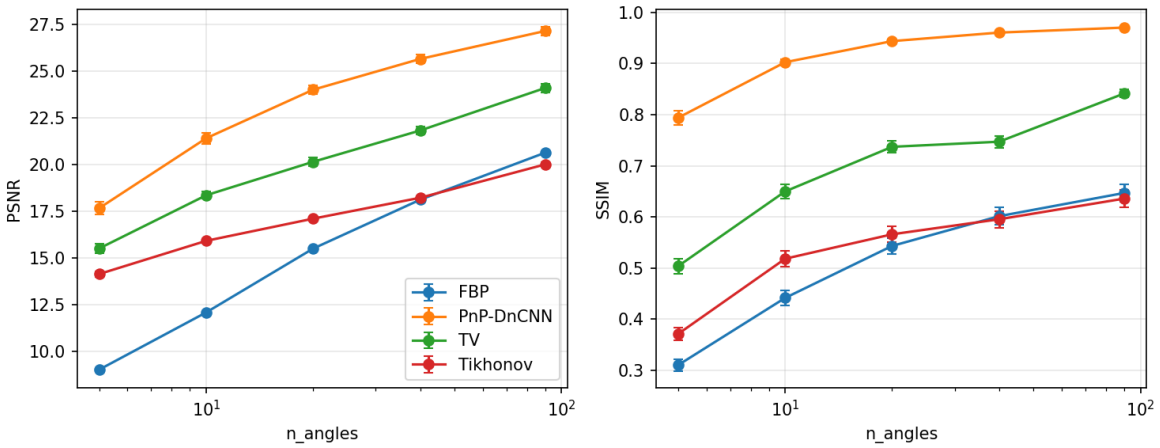


Figure 2: Reconstruction accuracy (PSNR, left; SSIM, right) vs. number of projection angles, for all four methods at a fixed measurement noise $\sigma = 0.05$. PnP-DnCNN is the top performer across the full range tested (5 to 90 angles); its advantage over TV is largest at 20–40 angles ($\approx +3.9$ dB) and smaller at the extremes ($+2.2$ dB at 5 angles, $+3.0$ dB at 90 angles). Error bars denote 95% confidence intervals over 200 test images.

TV is the strongest classical baseline throughout, consistent with MNIST digits being close to piecewise-constant. The learned prior overtakes TV as soon as the problem departs from the near noise-free, moderately-sampled regime. The PnP–TV gap peaks at about +3.9 dB, at $\sigma = 0.05$ with 20–40 angles; it is smaller at the extremes (+2.2 dB at 5 angles, +3.0 dB at 90 angles, +1.0 dB at $\sigma = 0.2$), with a corresponding SSIM improvement (0.74 for TV to 0.94 for PnP at $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles; full SSIM table in the project repository). At $\sigma = 0$ the learned prior underperforms TV by 6.4 dB and the two are statistically indistinguishable at $\sigma = 0.01$; Section 4.5 shows that the size of these two low-noise gaps depends on how well the data model matches the reconstruction model.

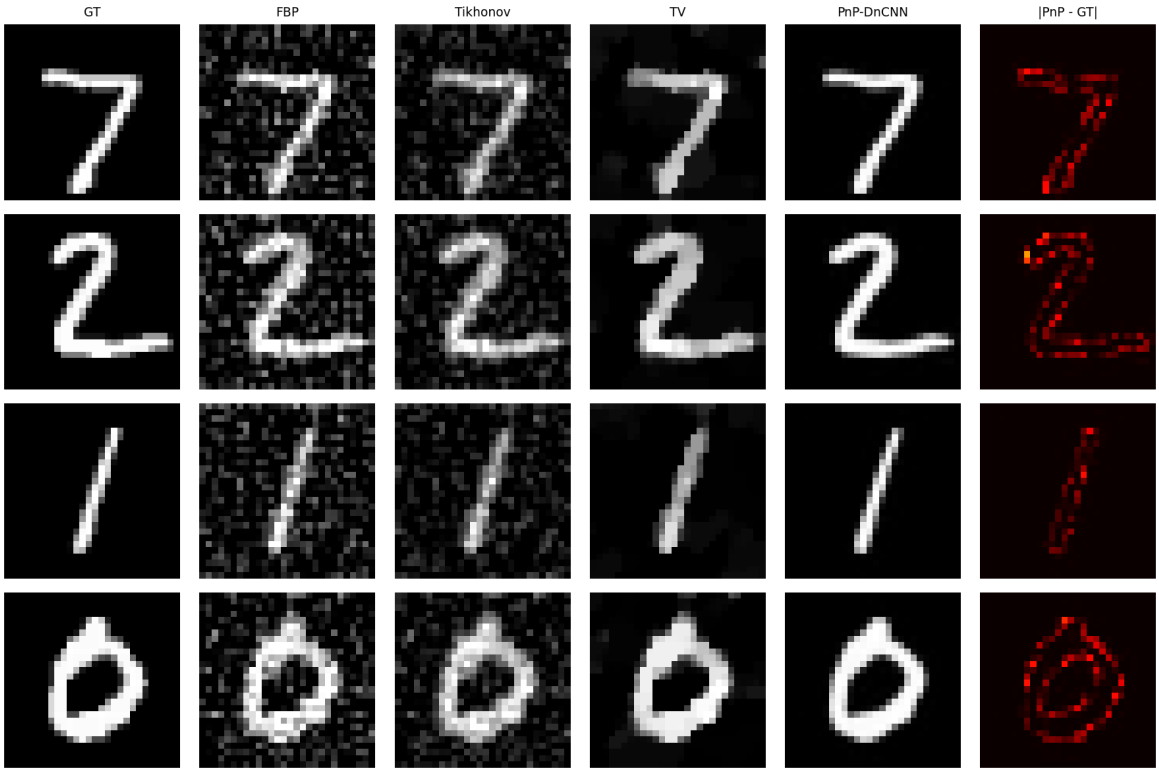


Figure 3: Qualitative in-distribution reconstructions at $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles. Each row is one test digit; columns show the ground truth, the three classical baselines, PnP-DnCNN, and the absolute error map $|\hat{x}_{\text{PnP}} - x|$ (brighter = larger error). FBP and Tikhonov retain visible measurement noise; TV produces flat, blocky regions; PnP-DnCNN recovers the sharpest, most faithful strokes. The error maps show that residual error is concentrated almost entirely along stroke boundaries, with near-zero error in flat background and interior regions.

4.2 E5: Why PnP selects few iterations

Validation tuning consistently selects a small number of PnP iterations (5–25 for ≥ 10 angles and $\sigma \leq 0.2$, and 100–400 for the 5-angle condition). Figure 4 shows PSNR and the data-fidelity residual $\|Ax_k - y\|$ as a function of iteration count, for several values of σ_d, on 50 test images. PSNR rises rapidly and peaks within the first 5–15 iterations, then *decays* to a lower plateau (e.g. $\sigma_d = 0.1$: peak ≈ 24.0 dB near iteration 10, plateau ≈ 22.0 dB by iteration 400). Over the same range, the residual does not decrease; it rises and plateaus, more steeply for larger σ_d. This indicates that the iteration does not converge to a fixed point that is simultaneously data-consistent and maximally

accurate: the denoiser's implicit prior increasingly dominates the data-fidelity term as iterations progress, without a corresponding gain in accuracy. Early stopping is therefore not an artifact of a coarse hyperparameter grid but an active, necessary part of the regularization.

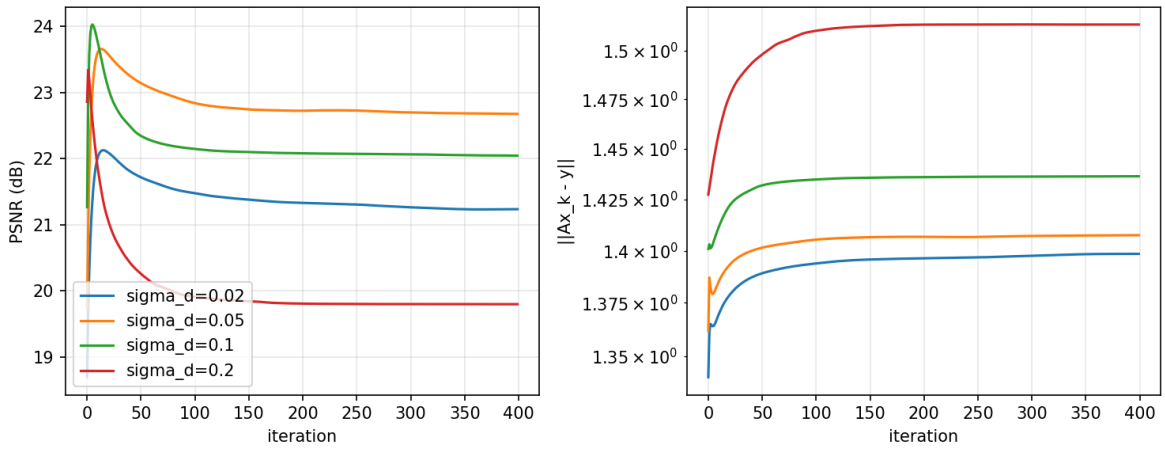


Figure 4: PnP-PGD convergence behavior for several denoising strengths σ_d (50 test images, $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles). Left: PSNR vs. iteration, peaking early then decaying. Right: data-fidelity residual vs. iteration, rising and plateauing rather than decreasing.

4.3 E3: Forward-model mismatch

Measurements are generated with the true 20-angle operator; reconstruction uses a perturbed operator with either a constant angle offset (rigid misregistration) or independent per-angle jitter, up to 4°, with all hyperparameters frozen at their $\sigma = 0.05$, 20-angle values. Table 2 summarizes the extremes of the tested range.

Table 2: Test PSNR (dB) under forward-model mismatch, hyperparameters frozen at nominal values.

Mismatch	TV ($0° \to 4°$)	PnP ($0° \to 4°$)	TV loss	PnP loss
Constant offset	$20.2 \to 18.6$	$24.0 \to 20.0$	1.6 dB	4.0 dB
Per-angle jitter	$20.2 \to 19.2$	$24.0 \to 22.2$	1.0 dB	1.8 dB

PnP remains more accurate than TV in absolute terms throughout the tested range, but degrades substantially faster in relative terms, particularly under a constant angular offset. Its advantage over TV narrows from +3.85 dB at zero mismatch to +1.48 dB at 4° offset.

4.4 E4: Distribution shift

The denoiser is trained exclusively on MNIST digits. We evaluate the full frozen pipeline (nominal $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles) on Fashion-MNIST, EMNIST letters, and a resized Shepp-Logan phantom (single image, 20 independent noise draws). Table 3 and Figure 7 summarize the results.

The learned prior generalizes to EMNIST letters, which share digits' stroke-based statistics, but underperforms TV on both far-shift test sets. Qualitatively (Figure 7), the failure mode is not

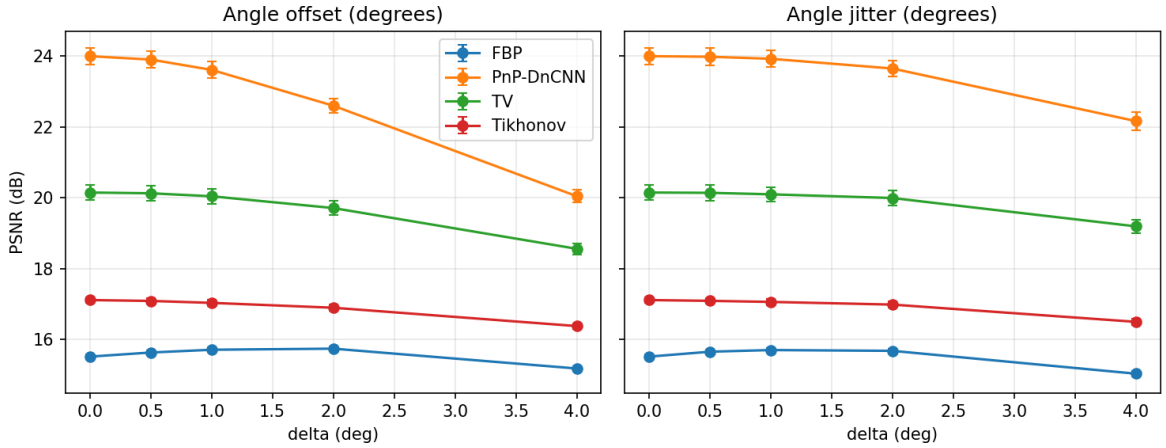


Figure 5: Test PSNR under forward-model mismatch, as a function of angular error δ (degrees), for a constant angle offset (left) and independent per-angle jitter (right). All hyperparameters are frozen at their nominal ($\delta = 0$) values and not retuned per mismatch level. PnP-DnCNN remains the most accurate method throughout the tested range, but degrades faster than TV, particularly under the systematic offset: its advantage over TV narrows from +3.85 dB at $\delta = 0$ to +1.48 dB at $\delta = 4°$. Error bars denote 95% confidence intervals over 200 test images.

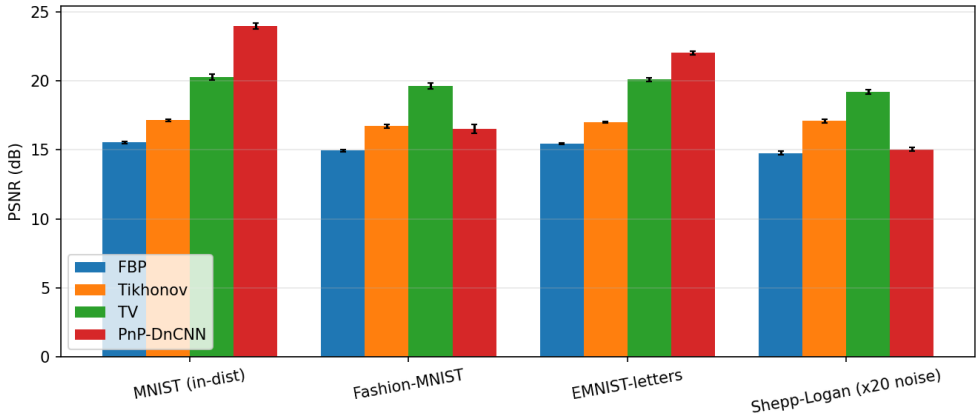


Figure 6: Test PSNR under train–test distribution shift, for all four methods, with the reconstruction pipeline frozen at its nominal ($\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles) hyperparameters. PnP-DnCNN leads on in-distribution MNIST and on EMNIST letters (a near-shift domain sharing digits' stroke-like statistics), but falls below TV and Tikhonov on Fashion-MNIST and the Shepp–Logan phantom (by 3.0 and 0.2 dB on Fashion-MNIST, by 4.2 and 2.1 dB on the phantom); it stays above FBP on Fashion-MNIST (16.6 vs. 14.9 dB) and only marginally so on the phantom (15.0 vs. 14.8 dB). TV is the most consistent performer across all four test sets. Error bars denote 95% confidence intervals; for the Shepp-Logan phantom, the interval reflects variation across 20 independent noise draws of a single image rather than variation across distinct images.

Table 3: Test PSNR (dB) under train–test distribution shift, frozen pipeline.

Test set	TV	PnP-DnCNN	PnP − TV
MNIST (in-distribution)	20.3	**24.0**	+3.7
EMNIST letters (near shift)	20.1	**22.0**	+1.9
Fashion-MNIST (far shift)	**19.6**	16.5	−3.1
Shepp-Logan phantom (far shift)	**19.2**	15.0	−4.2

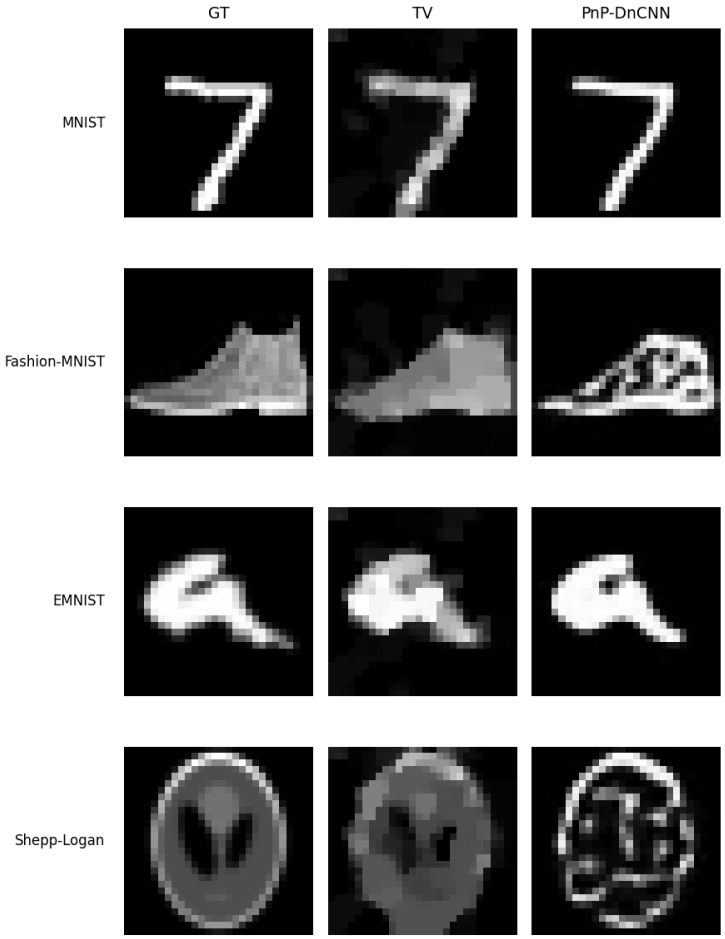


Figure 7: Qualitative reconstructions under distribution shift. The learned prior recovers structure well on MNIST and EMNIST (both stroke-like), but imposes hallucinated digit/stroke-like structure on Fashion-MNIST and the CT phantom, both structurally unlike the training distribution.

generic blur but hallucination: the denoiser imposes plausible-looking but incorrect digit/stroke-like structure on inputs unlike its training distribution.

4.5 E6: Sensitivity to the inverse crime

Table 4 compares the PnP–TV gap under four data models. For $\sigma \geq 0.05$ the model error is at most 7% of the noise norm and the in-distribution PnP–TV gaps change by at most 0.3 dB (bicubic data), so the conclusions of E1–E2 are unaffected. At $\sigma \leq 0.01$ they are not: TV remains ahead at $\sigma = 0$ in every variant, but by 5.9 dB with the nearest-neighbour object and by only 1.0 dB with the smoother bilinear object, and at $\sigma = 0.01$ PnP's lead ranges from +0.07 to +1.76 dB. The low-noise ranking is therefore a function of the forward-model mismatch rather than a single number, which also explains the sign of the $\sigma = 0$ result in E1. The out-of-distribution deficits of E4 persist in every variant (Fashion-MNIST: −2.8 to −3.9 dB; Shepp–Logan: −4.2 to −5.4 dB). We use bicubic data, the intermediate choice, as the default crime-free setting; Table 5 repeats the E1–E2 comparison with it.

Table 4: PnP−TV PSNR gap (dB), 20 angles, 200 test images, for four data models. "Model error" is the mean $\|\mathcal{S}(x) - Ax\|_2$; for comparison the noise norm $\sigma\sqrt{m}$ is 0.28, 1.41, 2.83, 5.66 for $\sigma = 0.01$, 0.05, 0.1, 0.2. Hyperparameters are re-tuned for each data model.

Data model	Model error	$\sigma = 0$	0.01	0.05	0.1	0.2
Same operator (inverse crime)	0	−6.43	+0.07	+3.86	+3.01	+1.03
Fine grid, nearest	0.03	−5.86	+0.16	+3.86	+3.01	+1.02
Fine grid, bicubic (default)	0.09	−3.29	+1.02	+4.02	+3.10	+1.08
Fine grid, bilinear	0.10	−0.97	+1.76	+3.94	+2.87	+0.85

Table 5: As Table 1, with measurements simulated on the finer grid (bicubic, $f = 5$); mean test PSNR (dB) over 200 images. Significance tests are provided with the repository results.

Condition	FBP	Tikhonov	TV	PnP-DnCNN	PnP−TV
$\sigma = 0$, 20 angles	24.3	27.4	33.2	29.9	−3.29
$\sigma = 0.01$, 20 angles	23.2	23.9	28.4	29.4	+1.02
$\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles	15.5	17.1	20.1	24.1	+4.02
$\sigma = 0.1$, 20 angles	10.4	14.7	16.8	19.9	+3.10
$\sigma = 0.2$, 20 angles	6.6	12.9	14.3	15.3	+1.08
5 angles, $\sigma = 0.05$	9.1	14.1	15.5	17.8	+2.36
10 angles, $\sigma = 0.05$	12.1	15.9	18.2	21.5	+3.29
40 angles, $\sigma = 0.05$	18.1	18.2	21.8	25.8	+3.97
90 angles, $\sigma = 0.05$	20.7	20.0	24.1	27.3	+3.24

4.6 E7: Error decomposition along the singular vectors

Table 6 reports the decomposition of Section 3.6 at $\sigma = 0.05$ and 20 angles ($\dim W_{0.05} = 319$). In distribution, PnP has about 0.4–0.5 times TV's error energy in *both* the weakly determined subspace and its complement (null-space ratio 0.48, range-space ratio 0.40) and a better-aligned completion of the unobserved directions ($c = 0.76$ versus 0.45): the prior's advantage is not confined to filling in unobserved directions. Under shift both ratios exceed 1 on Fashion-MNIST (1.27 and 2.32) and on

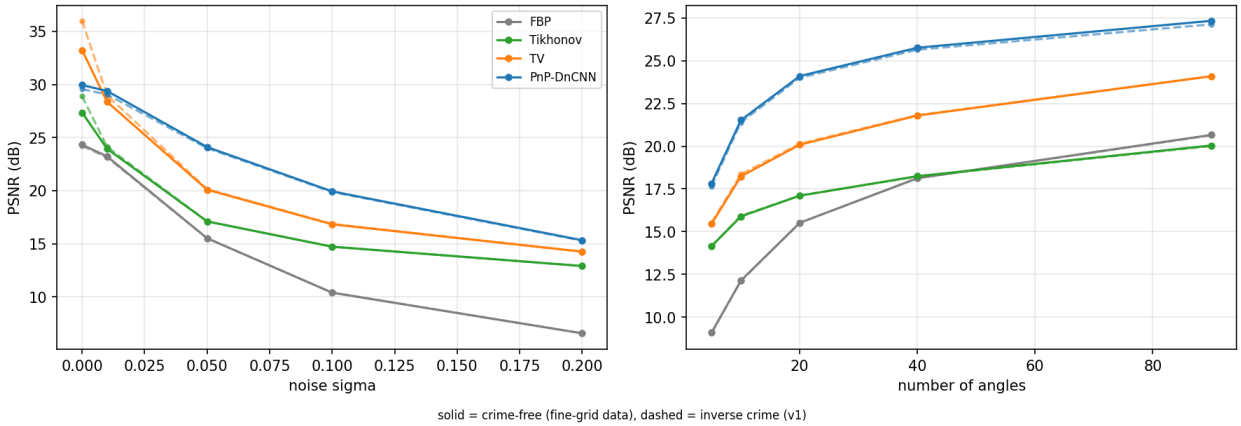


Figure 8: PSNR versus noise level (left) and number of angles (right) for data simulated on the bicubic finer grid (solid) and with the inverse crime (dashed). The curves coincide for $\sigma \geq 0.05$ and separate only at $\sigma \leq 0.01$, where TV loses most.

the phantom (2.59 and 2.64), so the failure is not confined to the weakly determined subspace either, and the largest part of the excess error lies in its complement. The injection statistic shows the hallucination signature: on the phantom PnP places 3.3 times the true energy in $W_{0.05}$ (TV: 0.44) with alignment 0.23, while on MNIST its 0.76 comes with alignment 0.76. Within the iteration, the contraction of direction i by the gradient step after K iterations is $(1-(s_i/s_1)^2)^K$, so at $K=5$ a direction with $s_i = 0.1\,s_1$ retains 95% of its initial error, $s_i = 0.3\,s_1$ 62% and $s_i = 0.5\,s_1$ 24%: the tuned iteration leaves a large share of directions to the denoiser. On the shifted sets no setting of (σ_d, K) recovers TV's accuracy: the best oracle setting still has 1.5–1.9 times TV's error and the error grows with K (to 3.7–4.6 times at $K = 400$; bilinear fine-grid data).

Table 6: Error decomposition at $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles, bicubic fine-grid data, $W_{0.05}$ (dim = 319). Ratios are PnP/TV (below 1: PnP has less error); ι is the injection and c the alignment statistic of Section 3.6.

	error ratio PnP/TV			ι		c	
Test set	in W	in $W^\perp$	total	TV	PnP	TV	PnP
MNIST (in-dist.)	0.48	0.40	0.42	0.58	0.76	0.45	0.76
EMNIST letters	0.70	0.64	0.65	1.22	1.55	0.43	0.67
Fashion-MNIST	1.27	2.32	2.05	0.29	0.80	0.36	0.37
Shepp–Logan	2.59	2.64	2.63	0.44	3.27	0.09	0.23

4.7 E8: Denoiser seeds and matched-prior control

Table 7 reports the shift experiment with three denoisers per configuration (bicubic data, $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles; all methods re-tuned on the validation distribution of the respective prior). Seed-to-seed variation is at most 0.3 dB, an order of magnitude below the effects of interest: on Fashion-MNIST the MNIST-trained prior is 3.10 ± 0.30 dB below TV (range -3.43 to -2.83) and on the phantom 4.33 ± 0.12 dB below. Training with $\sigma_{\max} = 0.5$ instead of 0.3 does not change these results (Fashion-MNIST -3.12, phantom -3.94 dB) and, at $\sigma = 0.2$, the tuned σ_d is 0.3 for all six MNIST denoisers although values up to 0.5 were available, so the grid-edge tuning in E1 was not an artefact; the

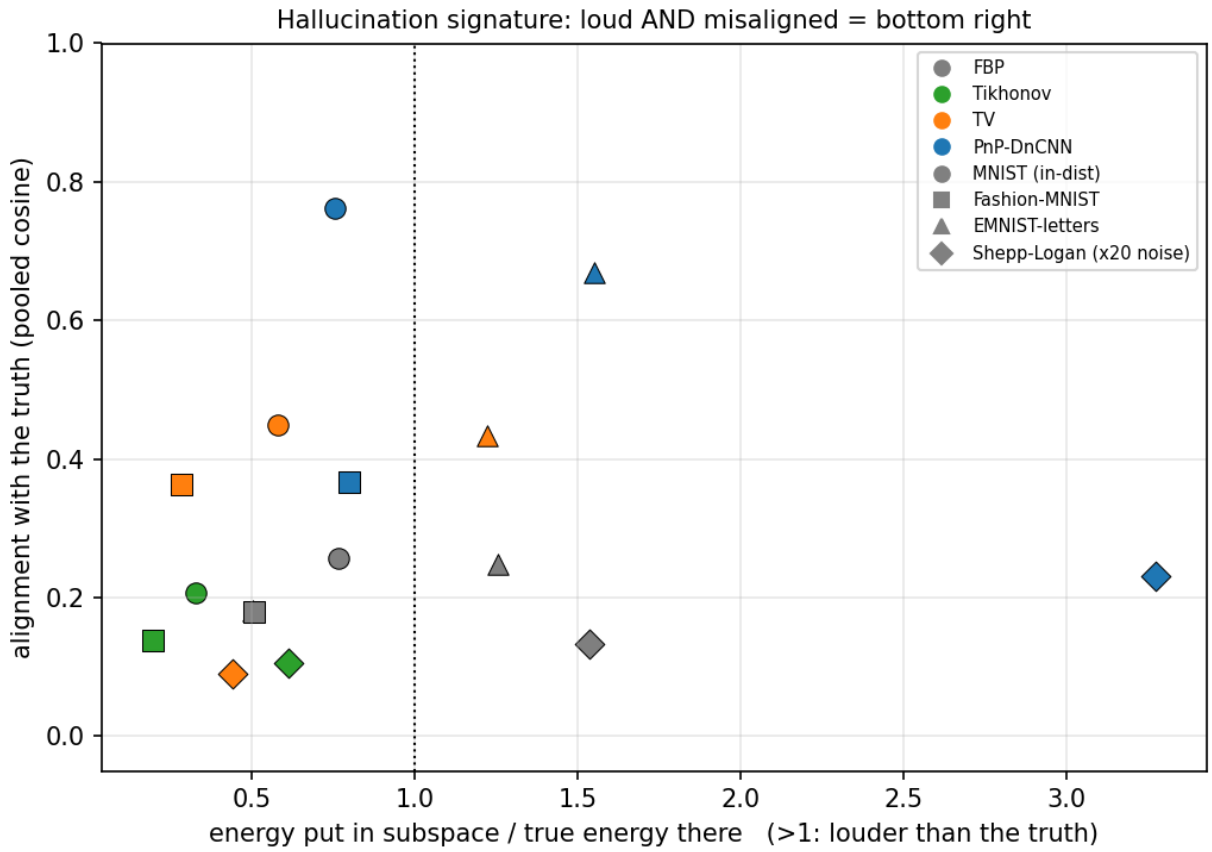


Figure 9: Hallucination signature (injection versus alignment in the weakly determined subspace) for TV and PnP-DnCNN on the four test sets (bicubic fine-grid data).

wider-range denoiser is slightly better at high noise ($+1.44 \pm 0.11$ versus $+0.97 \pm 0.11$ dB over TV at $\sigma = 0.2$, ranges not overlapping) and slightly worse at $\sigma = 0.05$.

The matched-prior control isolates the cause of the reversal: a prior trained on Fashion-MNIST beats TV on Fashion-MNIST by $+2.21 \pm 0.01$ dB (error ratio 0.63), although less than the MNIST prior on MNIST ($+3.84$ dB), since Fashion-MNIST images are less sparse. The control is clean: TV's PSNR is identical for all priors on every test set, i.e. tuning on Fashion-MNIST validation data selects the same TV weight. Transfer is asymmetric: the Fashion-trained prior still beats TV on MNIST ($+1.38$ dB) and ties it on the phantom (-0.18 dB, error ratio 1.05), whereas the MNIST-trained prior loses by 4.3 dB on the phantom. The injection statistic on the phantom follows the prior: 2.8–3.4 for MNIST-trained denoisers versus 0.30–0.35 for Fashion-trained ones, with identical noise and solver settings. Whether the broader prior helps because it is richer or because Fashion-MNIST resembles the phantom more cannot be decided with two training distributions.

Table 7: Distribution shift with three denoisers per prior (mean test PSNR in dB over seeds; gap = PnP−TV, mean ± s.d. over seeds). Bicubic fine-grid data, $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles; each prior's pipeline is tuned on the validation set of its own training distribution.

		MNIST-trained		Fashion-trained	
Test set	TV	PnP	gap	PnP	gap
MNIST	20.21	24.05	$+3.84 \pm 0.03$	21.60	$+1.38 \pm 0.09$
EMNIST letters	20.28	22.07	$+1.79 \pm 0.09$	20.73	$+0.44 \pm 0.09$
Fashion-MNIST	19.42	16.32	-3.10 ± 0.30	21.63	$+2.21 \pm 0.01$
Shepp–Logan	19.28	14.96	-4.33 ± 0.12	19.10	-0.18 ± 0.08

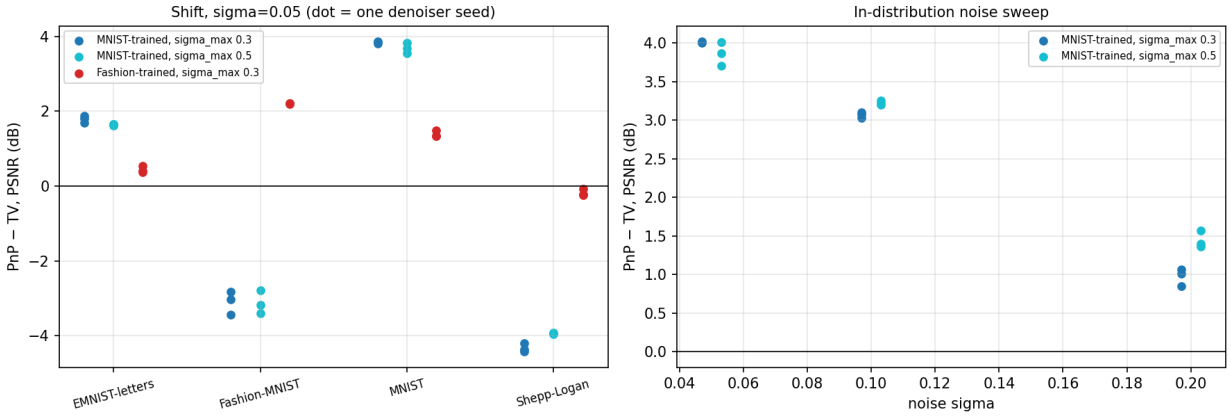


Figure 10: Left: PnP−TV gap for each denoiser seed (dots) on the four test sets, for three priors. Right: gap in the in-distribution noise sweep for MNIST-trained denoisers with $\sigma_{\max} = 0.3$ and 0.5.

4.8 E9: Lesion insertion

Table 8 and Figure 11 summarise the lesion experiment (three denoisers per prior, protocol of Section 3.8). Three observations hold across lesion types.

TV detects small lesions better than PnP, in distribution and for a matched prior. For the MNIST-trained prior on MNIST the paired AUC of PnP is 0.04–0.23 below TV's (for example 0.69

versus 0.91 for $\sigma_l = 0.75$, $c = 0.5$), although PnP is about 4 dB better in PSNR on the same images; for the matched Fashion-trained prior the deficit is 0.03–0.17. The two methods tie only for the largest high-contrast lesion. FBP and Tikhonov also detect small lesions better than PnP (paired AUC 0.92 at $\sigma_l = 0.75$, $c = 0.5$ on MNIST), at the cost of many false blobs (up to 6 per image for FBP).

In distribution PnP attenuates lesions and invents none. Its retention is 0.12–0.78 for the MNIST prior on MNIST and 0.16–0.49 for the matched prior (TV: 0.29–0.88 and 0.38–0.83), and it produces at most 0.01 false lesions per image against up to 0.26 for TV. The reconstructions are cleaner than TV's but the inserted lesion is often absent (Figure 12), so a visually convincing image does not imply a faithful one.

Under prior mismatch PnP invents structure. For the MNIST-trained prior on Fashion-MNIST the retention is 0.78–1.04 (the lesion survives) but there are 0.20–0.66 false lesions per image against ≤ 0.20 for TV, and the paired AUC remains below TV's by 0.05–0.16. The matched Fashion-trained prior on the same images produces at most 0.01. Lesion observability (Section 3.8) does not explain these differences: the observability terciles formed within each lesion type span only 0.87–0.95 on average, and PnP's AUC does not increase with observability; smaller lesions are harder for all methods, but this is confounded with size.

Table 8: Lesion insertion, mean over three denoisers per prior (200 test images, $\sigma = 0.05$, 20 angles, bicubic data), for two of the eight lesion types (σ_l/c = lesion size in px / contrast). pAUC: paired AUC; Ret.: retention; FL: false lesions per lesion-absent image. All methods use their PSNR-tuned settings.

		pAUC		Ret.		FL	
Prior → test set	σ_l/c	TV	PnP	TV	PnP	TV	PnP
MNIST → MNIST (in-dist.)	0.75/0.5	0.91	0.69	0.59	0.28	0.005	0.000
	1.25/0.25	0.90	0.69	0.62	0.30	0.005	0.000
MNIST → Fashion (shifted)	0.75/0.5	0.91	0.82	0.63	0.99	0.030	0.430
	1.25/0.25	0.93	0.76	0.59	0.87	0.030	0.428
Fashion → Fashion (in-dist.)	0.75/0.5	0.91	0.75	0.63	0.22	0.030	0.005
	1.25/0.25	0.93	0.80	0.59	0.23	0.030	0.005
Fashion → MNIST (shifted)	0.75/0.5	0.91	0.75	0.59	0.35	0.005	0.000
	1.25/0.25	0.90	0.78	0.62	0.36	0.005	0.000

4.9 E10: Can re-tuning recover lesion detectability?

The PSNR-tuned operating point of PnP is not necessarily the best one for lesion detection, so we sweep operating points (Section 3.8) and compare three rules for PnP—PSNR-tuned, best paired AUC on the selection set ("lesion"), and best paired AUC among points whose selection-set PSNR is at least that of tuned TV ("constrained")—with TV. Table 9 and Figure 13 show one denoiser per prior. For the MNIST-trained prior in distribution, the constrained point keeps a +0.7 dB PSNR advantage over TV (the PSNR-tuned advantage was +4.0 dB) but its paired AUC is still 0.06 below TV's, and its false-lesion rate rises to 12 times TV's; the lesion-tuned point matches TV's detection but has lower PSNR than TV and 60 times TV's false-lesion rate (0.32 versus 0.005 per image). For the matched Fashion-trained prior the constrained point keeps +1.0 dB over TV, with a paired AUC within 0.02–0.03 of TV's (about one standard error) and 0.085 false lesions per image against 0.03 for TV. Under shift, operating points chosen in distribution do not protect: for the MNIST prior on Fashion-MNIST all three rules are 2.1–2.8 dB below TV in PSNR and produce

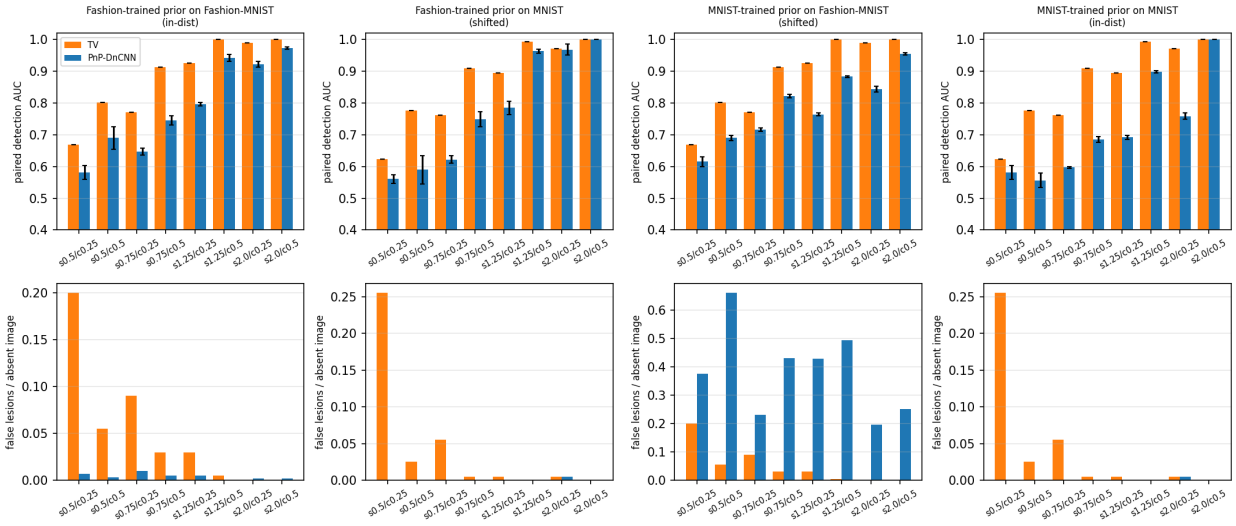


Figure 11: Paired detection AUC (top) and false lesions per lesion-absent image (bottom) for TV and PnP-DnCNN in the four prior/test-set combinations and the eight lesion types (mean over three denoisers; bars: s.d. over seeds).

0.40–0.51 false lesions per image against 0.03. Hence PSNR, detectability and fabricated structure trade against each other, and only a matched prior leaves a point at which PnP is competitive with TV on all three.

5 Discussion

Six findings emerge from this study.

First, the learned prior's accuracy advantage over TV is conditional rather than universal. It is large and significant at moderate noise and for moderate undersampling ($\approx +3.9\,\mathrm{dB}$ at $\sigma = 0.05$ with 20–40 angles), smaller at the extremes of both ranges, and in the near noise-free regime TV remains ahead by an amount that depends on how well the data model matches the reconstruction model (Section 4.5). Reporting a single aggregate accuracy number for a learned reconstruction method without specifying the operating regime and the data model is therefore misleading.

Second, PnP-PGD with an unconstrained CNN denoiser does not behave like a convergent optimization scheme: accuracy peaks after a handful of iterations and then degrades while the data residual rises (Section 4.2). This is consistent with the observation that convergence guarantees need constraints on the denoiser (e.g. non-expansiveness) [9]. Our decomposition adds a mechanism: with step $\eta = 1/L$ the data step contracts the error in direction i by $(1 - (s_i/s_1)^2)^K$, so after the few iterations selected by validation, directions with $s_i < 0.3\, s_1$ are barely corrected and the reconstruction there is largely the denoiser's. Iteration count is thus an implicit regularization hyperparameter, and not an implementation detail.

Third, the reversal under distribution shift is a failure of the prior, not of the scheme. The matched-prior control (Section 4.7) shows that PnP beats TV on Fashion-MNIST when the denoiser was trained on it, and the error decomposition shows that the mismatched prior places up to three times the true energy in the weakly determined subspace. The effect is robust: it exceeds seed-to-seed variation by an order of magnitude, persists under every data model we tested, and cannot be removed by changing σ_d or the iteration count. At the same time the failure is not confined to the

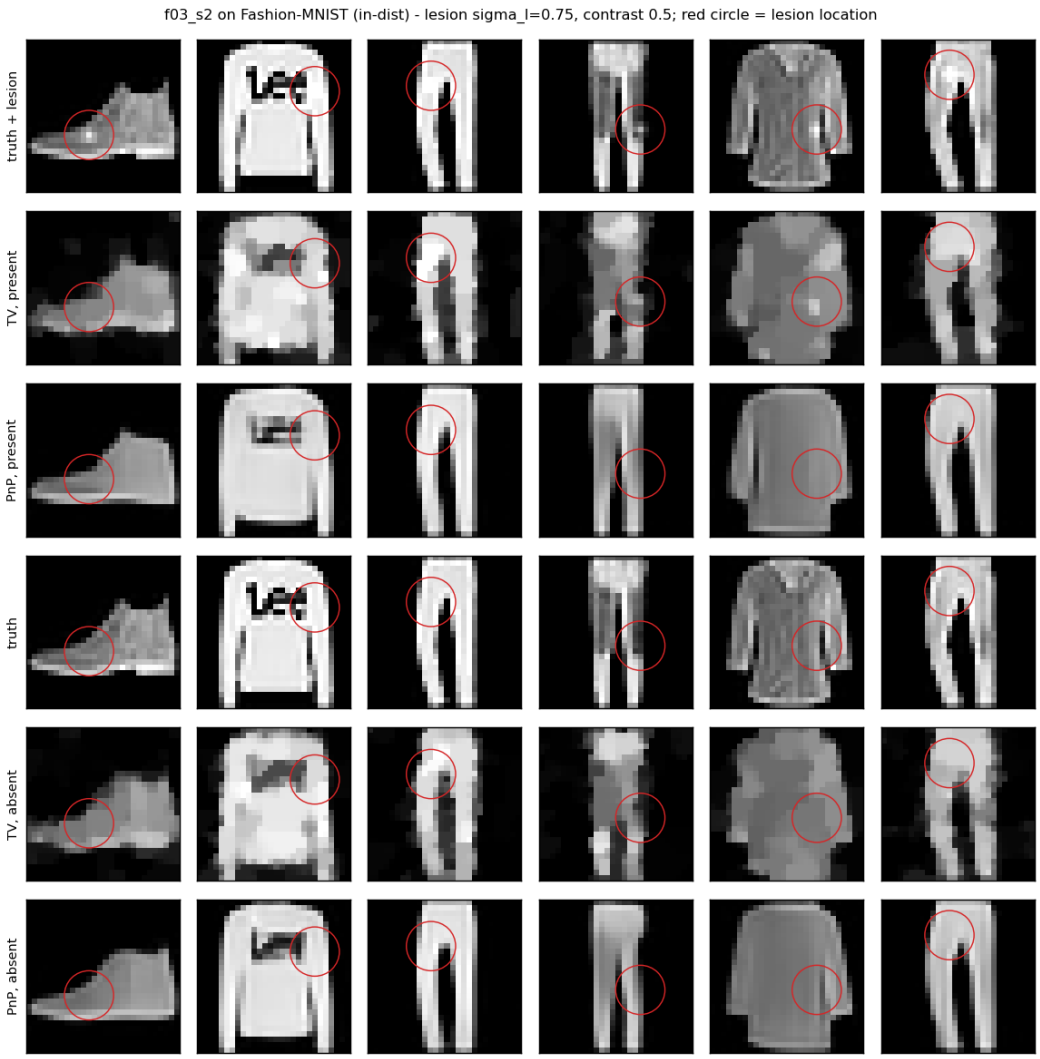


Figure 12: Matched Fashion-trained prior on Fashion-MNIST ($\sigma_l = 0.75$, $c = 0.5$). Rows: ground truth with lesion, TV and PnP reconstructions of the lesion-present image; ground truth, TV and PnP reconstructions of the lesion-absent image. The red circle marks the lesion location. PnP produces the cleaner images but removes the lesion.

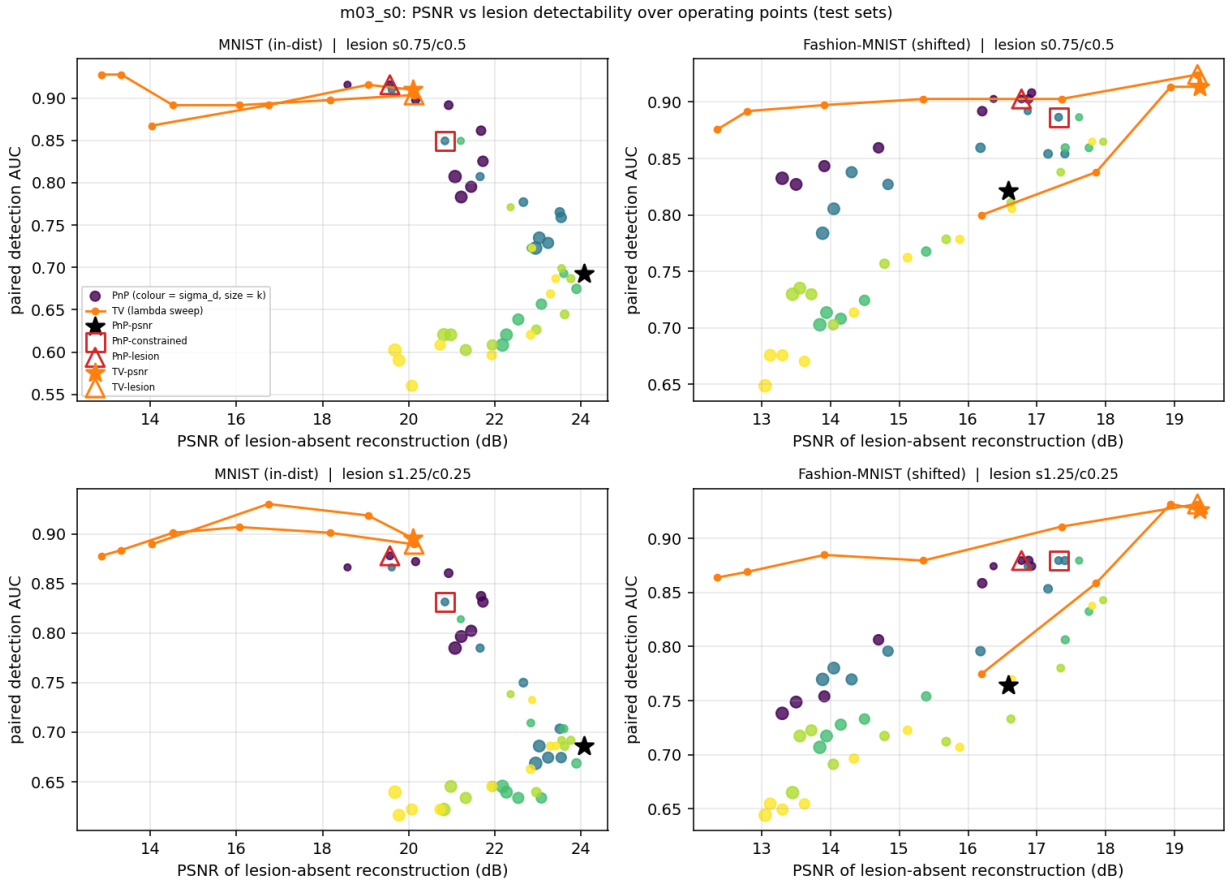


Figure 13: PSNR of the lesion-absent reconstruction versus paired detection AUC over all operating points of PnP (colour: σ_d; marker size: iterations) and TV (line: weight sweep) for the MNIST-trained denoiser. Markers show the selected operating points. Left: in distribution; right: Fashion-MNIST (shifted).

Table 9: Operating points for lesion type $\sigma_l = 0.75$, $c = 0.5$ on the test sets (one denoiser per prior; points chosen on held-out in-distribution validation images). PSNR is that of the lesion-absent reconstruction.

Prior → test set	Operating point	PSNR (dB)	pAUC	FL
MNIST → MNIST (in-dist.)	TV (PSNR-tuned)	20.11	0.910	0.005
	PnP, PSNR-tuned	24.07	0.693	0.000
	PnP, constrained	20.84	0.849	0.060
	PnP, lesion	19.57	0.916	0.315
MNIST → Fashion (shifted)	TV (PSNR-tuned)	19.37	0.914	0.030
	PnP, PSNR-tuned	16.58	0.822	0.420
	PnP, constrained	17.32	0.886	0.405
	PnP, lesion	16.78	0.903	0.505
Fashion → Fashion (in-dist.)	TV (PSNR-tuned)	19.37	0.914	0.030
	PnP, PSNR-tuned	21.58	0.751	0.005
	PnP, constrained	20.41	0.897	0.085
	PnP, lesion	19.07	0.870	0.255
Fashion → MNIST (shifted)	TV (PSNR-tuned)	20.11	0.910	0.005
	PnP, PSNR-tuned	21.67	0.759	0.000
	PnP, constrained	21.13	0.855	0.015
	PnP, lesion	21.21	0.898	0.040

weakly determined subspace, so "hallucination" in the null-space sense is an incomplete description.

Fourth, PSNR is not task performance. In distribution, the PSNR-tuned PnP reconstruction is about 4 dB better than TV yet detects small inserted lesions markedly less reliably, because it attenuates them (Section 4.8). The errors take two forms: erasure of unfamiliar small features when the prior is adequate, and invention of lesion-like blobs when it is not. Re-tuning trades one against the other (Section 4.9); only a matched prior leaves a point that is competitive with TV on PSNR, detection and false structure at once, and operating points chosen in distribution do not protect under shift.

Fifth, the learned method loses its advantage faster than TV under forward-model mismatch: it remains more accurate throughout the tested range but its margin falls from +3.85 dB to +1.48 dB at a 4° offset (Section 4.3). This experiment was run with data generated by the nominal operator and should be repeated on finer-grid data.

Sixth, evaluation protocol matters. The inverse crime changes the low-noise PnP–TV gap by up to 5.5 dB; a single denoiser instance would have reported anywhere between −2.83 and −3.43 dB for Fashion-MNIST depending on the seed; and operating points for the lesion task were therefore chosen on held-out images rather than on the evaluation images, to avoid overstating the benefit of re-tuning. These results are consistent with broader findings on instabilities in learned reconstruction [1, 5] and support the view that in-distribution accuracy alone is an insufficient basis for adopting a learned prior; mismatch, shift, seed and task-based evaluation should be a standard part of such studies, not an optional addendum.

6 Conclusion

We presented a controlled, small-scale comparison of classical and learned regularization for sparse-view CT reconstruction under noise, angular undersampling, forward-model mismatch, distribution shift and a lesion-detection task. The learned Plug-and-Play prior outperforms TV by up to ≈ 4 dB

at moderate-to-high noise and for 5–90 angles, but the advantage is conditional: the near noise-free ranking depends on the data model, the margin narrows under forward-model mismatch, and it reverses under distribution shift. The reversal is caused by a mismatched prior rather than by the PnP scheme: a prior trained on the shifted distribution beats TV on it, and the mismatched prior fills the weakly determined subspace with up to three times the true energy. In a task-based evaluation, the PSNR-tuned PnP reconstruction attenuates small lesions in distribution and invents lesion-like blobs under mismatch; re-tuning recovers TV-level detection only by giving up the PSNR advantage or by increasing false structure, except for a matched prior. The iteration used here lacks a stable, accurate fixed point, so early stopping acts as a regularizer. Future work should extend this study to larger, clinical-resolution data such as LoDoPaB-CT [7] with patient-disjoint splits, matrix-free operators and Poisson noise, and to provably convergent PnP variants and learned priors trained on diverse anatomy.

Limitations

The study is intentionally small (28×28 MNIST-derived images) so that a thorough experimental grid is possible; trends may not transfer to natural-image or clinical CT resolution and geometry. Experiments E1–E5 use data generated with the reconstruction operator (an inverse crime); the crime-free experiments E6–E10 use bicubic finer-grid data, and the sensitivity band of Table 4 shows that the near noise-free ranking depends on this choice. The convergence study (E5) and the forward-model mismatch study (E3) were not repeated on finer-grid data. Seed variation is estimated from three denoisers per configuration, which gives only a crude standard deviation, and the Shepp–Logan test set is a single image with 20 noise draws, so its intervals reflect noise rather than image variation. The error-decomposition statistics cannot separate prior-driven structure from amplified noise except in comparisons with identical noise and settings, and the observability analysis of lesions is confounded with lesion size and location. The lesion study uses bright additive Gaussian blobs, a location-known observer and a false-lesion threshold that is a modelling choice, so false-lesion rates are meaningful for comparing methods but not as absolute rates; the operating-point study uses one denoiser per prior, two lesion types and a coarse grid. Only two training distributions were compared, so the explanation of the asymmetric transfer between them remains a hypothesis. The PnP scheme has no convergence guarantee, and only moderate forward-model mismatches (up to 4°) were evaluated.

Reproducibility

Code, trained models, all raw result files and figures are available at `https://github.com/AboOraig/learned-regularization`. The experiments of this version are run, in order, by `run_nullspace.py` (E6, E7), `run_spectral.py` (iteration and spectral analysis), `run_step4.py` and `summarize_step4.py` (E8), `run_lesions.py` and `summarize_step5.py` (E9), and `run_oppoint.py` (E10); the unit tests are run with `python -m pytest tests`.

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